From Setbacks to Surprises

- Nitish Kumar's exit in early Jan. came as a big jolt to the INDIA bloc
- But running an aggressive campaign, they reduced the BJP to 240 seats in the Lok Sabha
- For the first time in years, the Opposition seemed capable of shaping the national agenda, inside and outside Parliament
- But the assembly poll upsets in Haryana and Maharashtra exposed chinks in Opposition unity

most visible faces, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar, defecting to the very camp he had been plotting to defeat! Nitish's pirouette to the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA), which sent shockwaves through the political landscape, was widely interpreted as a rejection of the Congress's keenness to capture centrality and control. For a coalition that had positioned itself as the panacea for precisely such tendencies in the BJP, this raised uncomfortable questions about the alliance's coherence and durability—a theme that echoed throughout the year.

But if INDIA stumbled at the start, it quickly found its footing, recalibrating its strategy with symbolic and substantive moves. The decision to boycott the Ram temple inauguration at Ayodhya was a bold statement, positioning the alliance as a defender of secularism. An aggressive campaign followed against the electoral bond scheme, which it framed as a vehicle for corruption and crony capitalism. Together, these helped INDIA craft a narrative that resonated with a wide swathe of voters concerned about constitutional erosion and economic inequalities.

Come June, and this culminated in an electoral performance that stunned even the most seasoned observers. The BJP was reduced to 240 seats in the Lok Sabha, well below majority. Though the NDA formed the government yet again, for the first time in years, the Opposition seemed capable of shaping the national agenda, both inside and outside Parliament. Most visible was its ability to compel the government to reverse controversial policies: just in August, the Broadcasting Services (Regulation) Bill, a notification for lateral recruitment in central ministries, and the Waqf (Amendment) Bill that had to go to a Joint Parliamentary Committee.



HINDUSTAN TIMES

The origin of the backronym INDIA remains unclear. The Congress credits Rahul Gandhi; others attribute it to Mamata Banerjee

But this was soon to be overshadowed by two assembly poll upsets—in Haryana and Maharashtra—that exposed its tactical naivete and internal disharmony. The Congress, seen as the weak link, faced public criticism from its partners, including Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee. These fissures, combined with the absence of a cohesive post-election vision, highlight the INDIA bloc's struggle to transition from an electoral coalition to a governance-oriented Opposition. ■